Extended essay: commentary for example essay			
DP subject: (Subject-focused essay)	**Business Management**		
DP subjects: (Interdisciplinary essay)		Interdisciplinary framework:	
Research question:	**To what extent is PayPal's success attributed to its differentiation strategies?**		
Assessment details			
Criterion:	Mark awarded:	Commentary: (Incorporating wording from the assessment criteria)	
A: Framework for the essay [Maximum possible mark: 6]	**4**	Research Question: relevant ('worth asking and investigating' about Paypal), clear (not ambiguous), focused (specific enough, but not too narrow). Research Methods: Secondary research is broadly suitable, but it is based only on journalistic sources: no academic source (see bibliography); besides, some sources are not suitable (ready-made analysis from the internet). Structure: Structural conventions are followed. NOTE: In the [3-4] markband, the examiner could hesitate between 3 and 4, but the clear structure (and subject-specific layout/presentation requirements with well labelled visuals) helps justify 4.	
B: Knowledge and understanding [Maximum possible mark: 6]	**5**	Knowledge: subject knowledge is comprehensive and relevant (e.g. positioning map of PayPal vs its competitors p8), even going beyond the syllabus (e.g. VRIO, Porter's model) Terminology: accurate and well used (e.g. about brand name or gross profit margin) Concepts: The EE is about the concepts of change, impact and globalization, but that could have been even more explicit. NOTE: In the [5-6] markband, the examiner could hesitate between 5 and 6, but for 6 the concepts should have been "used effectively" and that aspect could be stronger (analogy with criterion A of the IA).	

C: Analysis and line of argument [Maximum possible mark: 6]	**3**	Analysis: Through the application of business models, the analysis (of the data collected about PayPal and the digital payment industry) initially appears effective (both qualitatively and quantitatively), however so much of that analysis is not the student's own work (VRIO, 5 Forces) but just comes from webpages, so they do not show the candidate's own analytical skills. Line of argument: Initially clear, about differentiation and USP, but some occasional confusion (for example the link between VRIO and differentiation); the alignment between the RQ, the findings and the conclusions could be better. NOTE: In the [3-4] markband, the examiner could hesitate between 3 and 4, but the reliance on ready-made analyses found online helps justify a lower mark in the markband.
D: Discussion and evaluation [Maximum possible mark: 8]	**2**	Discussion: There is no discussion per se, it is only in the conclusion that the candidate starts bringing together their findings and discussing their significance. Evaluation: No evaluation of the effectiveness of the essay (neither its strengths nor limitations). NOTE: The examiner considered entering the [3-4] markband, however the total absence of any evaluation prevents that markband from being entered.
E: Reflection [Maximum possible mark: 4]	**3**	Evaluation: The candidate reflects candidly on their experience, in a balanced way (with both positive and negative aspects) and specific examples (e.g. initial research question, tools). Growth: In their own words, the candidate describes how they have grown (e.g. "dealing with frustration"). NOTE: The examiner could hesitate between 3 and 4; it is good to read how the student's voice genuinely comes through, however for 4 marks they should have addressed the issue of skills and transfer of learning more explicitly.
Total marks awarded	17/30	
Holistic comment on the essay:	An interesting case study (based on clear subject knowledge and relevant concepts) – the main issue is the fact that the candidate relied so much on "ready-made analyses" found online; of course they are duly	

	acknowledged and referenced, but the question remains – how much of the analysis is the student's own work?